

EXHIBITION

All That is INDIAN

The fascination with Indian art in the West is growing by the day and Saatchi Gallery in London taps into it with an exhibition of Indian contemporary art, *The Empire Strikes Back: Indian Art Today*. Charles Saatchi's interest in Indian art is well-known and his Chelsea gallery showcases the work of 26 emerging and established artists.

Bharti Kher, 41 The artist explores cultural misunderstandings and social codes in her work. Kher is heavily influenced by her upbringing in the UK and her subsequent move to New Delhi in 1993 after studying art in Newcastle. Highly regarded for her sculptural work, Kher, showcases a sculpture of the heart of a blue sperm whale, one of the world's largest animals. Created in fibreglass, she decorates the heart and veins with different coloured bindis.

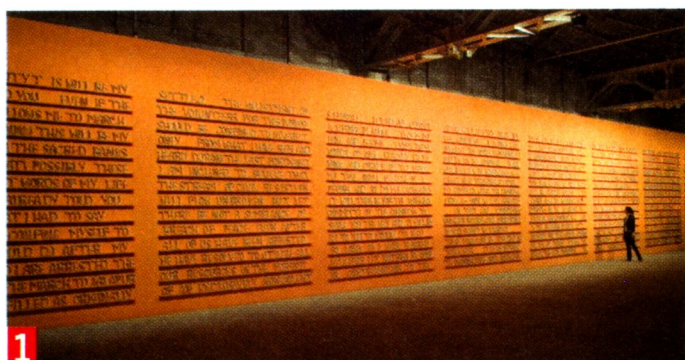
Pushpamala N., 54 The Bangalore-based Pushpamala is a photo and video performance artist, who frequently uses herself as a model in her work. On display are 45 sepia-toned silver gelatin prints from her ethnographic series, *Native Women of South India: Manners & Customs*. In collaboration with photographer Clare Arni, she dresses in period costume and tries to refashion old stereotypes of women featured in early anthropological studies.

Chitra Ganesh, 35 In her collection *Tales of Amnesia*, the New York-based artist uses simplified comic strips to characterise the age-old battle of good and evil. On display will also be *Secrets and Hidden*. *Hidden* depicts Ganesh performing bizarre acts of mutilation.

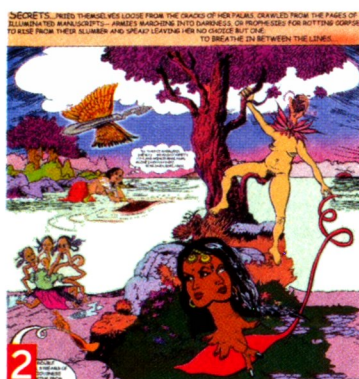
Jitish Kallat, 36 The artist's work deals with Mumbai's dislocated and downtrodden inhabitants. In *Public Notice 2*, Kallat constructs a key speech of Mahatma Gandhi out of 4,500 recreations of bones shaped like alphabets. The speech was made on the eve of the historic Salt March to Dandi that lasted 24 days during the freedom struggle.

Subodh Gupta, 46 The Delhi-based artist chooses signature objects of India and places them as art objects in installations of stainless steel and tiffin-tins. In *Spill*, a stainless steel water vessel sits with many smaller steel utensils spilling over the edge like water pouring out. Repetition of forms and the exaggeration of scale is a common element in Gupta's work.

by Nishika Patel



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1. KALLAT'S *PUBLIC NOTICE* 2; 2. GANESH'S *SECRETS*; 3. GUPTA'S *SPILL*; 4. KHER'S *AN ABSENCE OF ASSIGNABLE CAUSE* AND 5. PUSHPAMALA POSING IN HER ETHNOGRAPHIC SERIES